chivvying them along like prisoners of war, they slipped out in plain sight of the Mughal army, as audaciously as they had shot at them these past four months. Akbar, meanwhile, did not linger to savour his victory. Only three days later, disappointed, perhaps, at having been cheated of his revenge on the marksmen who had plagued him, Akbar left Chittorgarh and set off on his first-ever pilgrimage of thanks to the dargah of Moinuddin Chishti in Ajmer.[48]

He went on foot. It was a vow he had made, in the hope of divine blessing for his campaign, but walking was also one of Akbar's many passions. Some years before, after a hunt in Mathura, he declared he would walk back to Agra. His unhappy courtiers had little choice except to stumble along behind their king as he strode the full 60 kilometres back home. None but three men, according to Abul Fazl, 'were able to keep pace with him'. Now, on 28 February 1568, as Akbar set off 'stage by stage over the burning desert-sands' his hapless nobility and harem was constrained, once again, to 'do as he did'. Chittorgarh to Ajmer was no 60 kilometre stroll, however. At some point, his walking companions seem to have gathered their flagging energies to sabotage their padishah's plan. One-third of the way through their journey, in Mandal, an envoy of Akbar's who had gone ahead to apprise the Chishtis of his arrival, returned with some ascetics from the dargah. Shaikh Moinuddin himself had come to them in a dream, said the fakirs, urging them to dissuade Akbar from coming for, 'If he knew the amount of his own spirituality he would not bestow a glance on me . . .'

Immediately, Akbar decided to ride the rest of the way. Not even Chishti saints from heaven could dissuade the padishah once he'd made up his mind, but it might yet be possible for earthly mortals to manipulate his will – whether by threatening rebellion or, more simply, flattery.

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From Abul Fazl and Badauni onwards, Akbar's biographers have tended to be of two broad types: those who write with breathless awe, and those who write with scorn. These reactions are not always triggered by the same causes – if Abul Fazl finds in Akbar a perfection of human attributes, a colonial historian called G.B. Malleson admires the unifying imperative that guided Akbar's policies. If Badauni railed against Akbar's religious